

Hybrid thermal-mechanical treatment using localized heating during rail joint welding while simultaneously applying crack-resistant material inserts

Executive Technology Brief

Domain: thermal

Technology Maturity: ENGINEERING_DEFINITION

Transfer Posture: Sponsored Validation

Problem: Documented recurring problem 'rail steel fatigue fracture' (broken rails/joints, FRA cause family T2): 3 of 25 FRA Form 54 accidents in the retrieved window are broken-rail/joint-caused, derailing 17 cars total. Causes observed: 'Broken Rail - Base [Desc.Changed-Refer to Current/Prev.Guides]'; 'Mismatched rail-head contour'. LIMITS STAMPED INLINE: carrier-reported regulatory reports; cause codes are classifications of the initial report, NOT proven root causes; reportable-above-threshold events only (Art. XXI.5 analog).

Mechanism: Thermite welding combined with hydrogen-resistant material inserts to prevent embrittlement and enhance fracture toughness

Architecture: PROPOSED architecture (no physical system exists): heat source characterization; conduction path / spreader; reject interface; safety limit interlock — realizing: Hybrid thermal-mechanical treatment using localized heating during rail joint welding while simultaneously applying crack-resistant material inserts

Governing Model: Thermal management / heat transfer governing relations proposed for this invention; SYMBOLIC ONLY until inputs are sourced

Key Equations:

TH-002: Convective heat transfer (Newton's law of cooling). Expression: $q = h * A * dT$. Applicability to this invention: APPLICABLE; holds under: steady state; h characterized for the actual flow geometry. Assumptions: h correlations are geometry- and regime-specific; using a correlation outside its validated range is forbidden. Engaged variables: dT .

TH-003: Series thermal resistance. Expression: $R_{total} = \sum(L_i / (k_i * A_i))$. Applicability to this invention: APPLICABLE; holds under: one-dimensional steady conduction through layers. Assumptions: interface contact resistances dominate at small scale and must be measured, not assumed zero. Engaged variables: R_{total} .

TH-001: Fourier conduction. Expression: $q = -k * A * dT/dx$. Applicability to this invention: APPLICABLE; holds under: steady state, isotropic conduction. Assumptions: steady-state conduction (no transient term); isotropic, homogeneous medium conductivity k ; one-dimensional gradient (lateral gradients neglected). Engaged variables: k , dT/dx .

Kill Condition: killer experiment fails: falsification_test_from_candidate (decision scores: EIG 0.44573539382492045, EIG-per-cost 0.44573539382492045; the falsification test carries the pre-registered pass/fail before any transfer)

Current State: ENGINEERING_DEFINITION. No physical prototype. No clinical validation.

Disclosure: This dossier distinguishes established evidence from proposals and unresolved questions.